These successes in the shorter format of the game inspired general confidence that this team could be successful at the 2009 ICC World Twenty20 tournaments, played in England, and we started our campaign impressively with a 130-run victory over Scotland. Albie Morkel and I had managed to add 50 runs in 19 balls as we made 211 in 20 overs, and Dale Steyn and Wayne Parnell reduced the Scots first to 50 for six and then 81 all out.

With hosts England losing their opening match to the Netherlands at Lord's, cricket writers started to proclaim the Proteas favourites for the title, showing the home side precisely how to dispatch lesser teams and cope with the pressures of playing in a World Cup. Criticism can be dispiriting, I thought, but praise can be significantly more dangerous.

The format of the competition meant our next match, against New Zealand at Lord's, was a dead rubber, but we worked hard to defend a low total and edged a one-run victory. It wasn't pretty, but it was another win, another step on the path to winning an official ICC trophy, on the way to getting rid of our dreaded reputation. Don't mention the C-word.

Moving into the so-called Super Eights, we overcame England at Trent Bridge, and when we defeated the West Indies at The Oval media flattery reached a new level. 'In an unpredictable format,' wrote one journalist, 'the powerful and resolved South Africans look unbeatable.'

A further victory over India at Nottingham, when I contributed 63 runs from 51 balls in a low-scoring contest on a low pitch, was our sixth T20 victory in a row, and we moved towards a semifinal against Pakistan with a growing belief that this would be the tournament when we would hold our nerve, when the little moments would go our way.

Jeremy Snape, our excellent team psychologist, even dared to mention the C-word. He told us how the 'chokers' had become the 'stranglers', making reference to our bowlers' ability to exert control, restrict the run rate and defend relatively low totals. Coach Mickey Arthur was pushing the same messages, that we were a team that had moved on from the disappointments of the past, a team with no fear of losing.